Roadmap: from chip to an embodied, closed-loop fly

What NeuroMPS builds next, after the final round. The plan below is a commitment, not a result: nothing in it has been run yet except where a number cites `outputs/metrics.json`. Everything it will produce is simulated, for research decision support; none of it is a claim about any compound's effect in any animal or person.

Slide message: *Today we read a simulated fly brain as a chip and as an animal, through the neurons that drive behaviour. Next we give it a body and close the loop, so that the question "does the chip flag a drug before behaviour fails?" can be asked of movement itself, with sensory feedback in place. Each stage has a registered go/no-go test.*

1. Why close the loop

The chip-to-animal study (report Act VII) reads behaviour as the firing of named neurons, down to the motor neurons of the male nerve cord. Three things it cannot see:

- **Movement.** A motor neuron firing faster is not a leg moving differently. Muscles, joints and contact with the ground turn firing into behaviour, and they can mask or amplify a change.
- **Feedback.** In a real fly, movement is sensed and fed back: leg proprioceptors report joint angles and loads to the nerve cord and brain. A drug that disturbs a circuit inside a loop can have effects an open-loop model misses, in either direction.
- **The environment.** Feeding is a sequence (find, taste, extend the proboscis), not a firing rate; grooming is a sequence of leg sweeps.

Our current results are the baseline the embodied model has to be compared against. On the simulated fly brain, the chip's firing rate ranks drugs by how much they disrupt behaviour (Spearman 0.863), but it raises the alarm late. At the motor neurons of the male nerve cord, the chip is later than motor output in 4 drug families, level in 1, and never earlier. And electrodes on the brain's output tract caught GABA block in time where a planar array did not (0.361 against 0.044 log2). The embodied model asks whether these conclusions survive movement and feedback.

2. What already exists

Layer	Status	Where
Whole-brain model (FlyWire), drug knobs by transmitter class	built, validated against the published sugar→MN9 result	`src/neuromps/fly/model.py`; report §23
Brain and nerve cord (MaleCNS, 165,122 neurons)	built; replicates the behaviour results	`fly/malecns.py`; §25
Virtual MEA scored by the chip's own extractor	built	`fly/electrodes.py`, `features/mea.py`
Motor-neuron readouts (proboscis, front legs, all motor neurons)	built, registered study done	`fly/motor.py`; §25
Neuron-to-muscle map	in the data: 260 of 381 leg motor neurons are typed by the muscle they drive	`fly/roadmap_inventory.py`
Feedback neurons	in the data: 1,030 proprioceptive sensory neurons in the nerve cord, among them 403 chordotonal-organ and 175 campaniform-sensilla neurons	`fly/roadmap_inventory.py`
Body and physics	available, not yet used: NeuroMechFly v2 (FlyGym) and flybody, both on MuJoCo, all Apache-2.0	external

3. The loop we will close

1. **Brain and nerve cord** (MaleCNS, leaky integrate-and-fire, the drug knobs as now).
2. **Motor neurons to muscles.** Each leg motor neuron typed by its muscle drives that muscle's activation; the untyped ones are mapped by their connectivity to typed partners, or left out and reported.
3. **Muscles to joints.** Muscle activations become joint torques in the body model (NeuroMechFly v2's leg joints).
4. **Body and world.** MuJoCo integrates the body against the ground, with leg adhesion, and against a sugar spot for feeding.
5. **Joints back to neurons.** Joint angles and contact forces drive the matching proprioceptive sensory neurons (chordotonal organs for angles, campaniform sensilla for load), which re-enter the network.

The chip side does not change: the same virtual array, scored by the same extractor, read while the fly behaves.

4. Stages, each with a registered go/no-go test

Stage	When	Deliverable	Go/no-go test (registered before it runs)
1. Open-loop legs	weeks 1–3	front-leg motor neurons drive NeuroMechFly's front legs	antennal drive produces front-leg sweeps toward the head that untreated, undriven runs do not
2. Feeding and walking	weeks 3–6	proboscis extension from the proboscis pool; walking from descending commands	sugar drives proboscis extension and bitter suppresses it; a walking command produces an alternating gait
3. Close the loop	weeks 6–10	proprioceptive feedback into the nerve cord	feedback measurably changes the movement (it stabilises or reshapes the rhythm) against the open-loop run
4. Drugs in the loop	weeks 10–14	the registered chip-to-animal design rerun with movement as the readout	registered predictions, among them: does the chip still flag drugs after movement fails; does the output-tract electrode still lead
5. Check against real flies	weeks 14–18	comparison with published fly pharmacology (feeding and grooming under GABA-A and GluCl drugs)	the direction of each published behavioural change is reproduced, or the mismatch is reported
6. Release	weeks 18–20	open code, models and a paper	one command reproduces every number, as now

Each stage stops if its test fails, and the failure is reported, as every failed prediction in this project has been.

5. What it would change for organ-on-a-chip

The embodied model lets three chip-design questions be asked of behaviour itself rather than of neurons:

- **Sensitivity.** How small a firing-rate change must a chip resolve to flag each mechanism before movement fails? Today's answer comes from interneurons and motor neurons (report §24).
- **Electrode placement.** Does recording the connection between compartments (the output tract, a chip's microchannels) still lead a planar array when behaviour is movement under feedback?
- **Screen thresholds.** How does a regulatory screen's hit cutoff compare with the change at which movement, not firing, fails?

6. Risks, and how each is handled

Risk	Handling
Part of the neuron-to-muscle map is missing (motor neurons not typed by muscle)	map the rest by connectivity to typed partners; report coverage; test robustness by leaving the uncertain ones out
A leaky integrate-and-fire nerve cord may not generate rhythms (walking needs them)	stage 2's go/no-go test catches it; then add the intrinsic currents rhythm generation needs, as a stated change
The male nerve cord is over-excitable under the published weight (any drive recruits many motor neurons)	calibrate one weight against the untreated motor recruitment before stage 4, registered
Real fly pharmacology is sparse and in different units	stage 5 compares directions, not magnitudes, and says which comparisons were impossible
Compute	FlyGym 2 simulates on GPU; the GB10 runs the network and the body in parallel

7. Status, and what stage 1 changed

Stage 1 ran and failed its go/no-go test, as did its registered follow-up. The male-CNS network was wired to the FlyMimic leg (MuJoCo 3.16, the leg's 15 Hill-type muscles driven by 49 of the 68 left front-leg motor neurons, by name). Antennal drive moved the claw toward the head in every trial, but sugar drive moved it closer still (median closest approach 0.9386 against 1.1067 mm): the movement was not specific. Stage 1b rescaled the male-CNS weight by the ratio of synaptic input per neuron between the connectomes; at that weight sugar no longer drove the feeding motor neuron at all (0.0 Hz), so its leg results are uninterpretable, as registered.

What went wrong. The same sugar drive puts 251 neurons above 10 Hz in the published FlyWire model and 14,263 in the male CNS at the same weight, most of them central-brain neurons (11,082 of 32,160); at the rescaled weight still 7,586. The published model's parameters do not carry over to the second connectome's brain: there, activity avalanches, and lowering one global weight silences weak pathways before it stops the avalanche. This is itself a result for the paper, and it changes the plan.

The revised plan. Use each connectome where its model is validated:

- **Stage 1c (next):** drive the male nerve cord from its descending neurons alone, without the male brain. Activating the descending neurons the literature ties to antennal grooming should move the front leg toward the head; descending neurons for other behaviours should not. This tests the nerve cord, the muscle map and the leg without the brain's avalanche.
- **Then:** join the FlyWire brain, where the published model is validated, to the male nerve cord through descending neurons matched by cell type across the two connectomes.

Both steps are registered before they run, like every stage.

8. What carries over unchanged

Pre-registration before every run; licensed data with checksums in the manifest; every reported number written by a script and checked against the documents that cite it; failed predictions reported beside the passed ones; and a demo anyone can open.